



AI IMAGES

INDIA'S SHIPPING has a chequered past. The country is home to the world's oldest known dockyard—likely built during the Indus Valley civilisation era—in Lothal in the Bhal region of Gujarat. The memory of its glorious maritime past lives on in festivals such as *Boita Bandna* in Orissa which celebrates past voyages to Southeast Asian countries.

But that is history, most it is forgotten. At present, India accounts for less than 1% of the world's ship-building capacity. China, South Korea and Japan together account for 98.5% of global ship building. China's share is 60%.

India aspires to join that exalted club.

The government has approved a ₹69,725-crore package to make the country one of the top 10 ship-building

nations by 2030 and one of the top five by 2047. Indian shipyards, driven by demand from the Navy, have been focused on domestic waters. The government is nudging them to target exports. Mazagon Dockyard Ltd (MDL), Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers Ltd (GRSE), Goa Shipyards Ltd (GSL) and Cochin Shipyard Ltd (CSL) have been asked to transform India from a regional manufacturer of patrol corvettes and small ships to a global builder of frigates, cadet training ships and modular warships for Southeast Asia, Latin America and Africa.

The players will need all hands on deck as they take on established giants China, South Korea and Japan, but they have a few things going for them. The foremost